Spring (Spring Food Limited)

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Executive Summary

Spring Food Limited is raising £500,000 at a £2.5m pre-money valuation, offering 16.67% equity. Revenue declined 30% to £600,000 in 2025 at a 29% gross margin, and the company remains loss-making. The good-case exit NPV is £367k on a £500k investment; the bad case returns just £28k. Key risks include a single-director structure, no proprietary technology, declining revenue, and insufficient downside protection for investors. The valuation is ambitious relative to current fundamentals. This report recommends **not investing at this stage**, as the risk-return profile does not justify the capital deployed.

Opportunity

Problem

Bone broth has been consumed for years, but it is now increasingly repositioned as a "superfood," linked to benefits such as improved gut health and energy recovery (Fortune Business Insights, 2026). A key characteristic of this product is its long preparation process, with brands like Spring claiming it can take more than 48 hours to fully develop its nutritional value. Spring tries to differentiate itself from the highly processed soups and broths typically found in supermarkets (Crowdcube Capital Limited, 2026; Bone, 2024), arguing that consumers are left choosing between low-quality ready-made options and time-intensive homemade alternatives.

However, this positioning can be challenged. Although Spring emphasises the time and complexity involved, many recipes suggest that bone broth can be prepared at home in less time. Even beef bone broth, which is the most time-consuming variation, generally requires up to 36 hours rather than over 48 hours to avoid overcooking (Pauly, 2025). This reduces the strength of Spring's argument around convenience.

Solution

Spring proposes ready-to-eat, nutrient-rich bone broths and soups, differentiated by 100% British farm-sourced ingredients, a broad product range, and a 24-month shelf life. For consumers, this aims to remove the time and effort of home preparation. However, the pitch does not provide primary evidence that this inconvenience constitutes a significant consumer pain point. McLoughlin (2025) shows UK consumers are actively reducing meal preparation times, averaging under 15 minutes for lunch occasions, which supports the convenience case in general, but does not confirm demand specifically for pre-made bone broth over simpler, cheaper alternatives such as stock cubes or supermarket soup.

Although Spring's offering aligns with current trends, the pitch provides no primary evidence that consumers are willing to pay £10.13 per bottle for bone broth specifically, rather than cheaper alternatives such as stock cubes or supermarket soup. A further concern is the absence of any proprietary protection. Spring discloses no patents, exclusivity agreements, or switching costs that would prevent replication. The 100% British sourcing and natural production methods are presented as differentiators, but Borough Broth and Freja position themselves

around near-identical attributes (Borough Broth, 2026; Freja Foods, 2026), and established brands already benefit from existing consumer loyalty (Kemsley, 2025).

Scalability

Market Potential

The global healthy food market is expected to grow significantly, increasing from USD 897.0 billion in 2025 to approximately USD 2.2 trillion by 2035 (Future Market Insights, 2025), providing broad macroeconomic tailwinds relevant to Spring's positioning. Within this, the global bone broth market remains relatively small but expanding, valued at USD 1.21 billion in 2025 and projected to grow to USD 2.04 billion by 2034 (Fortune Business Insights, 2026a). However, this growth is expected to be mainly driven by chicken-based products due to their lower cost, Spring's premium, multi-variant offering does not straightforwardly align with where demand growth is actually concentrated, which raises questions about how much of this TAM Spring can realistically address.

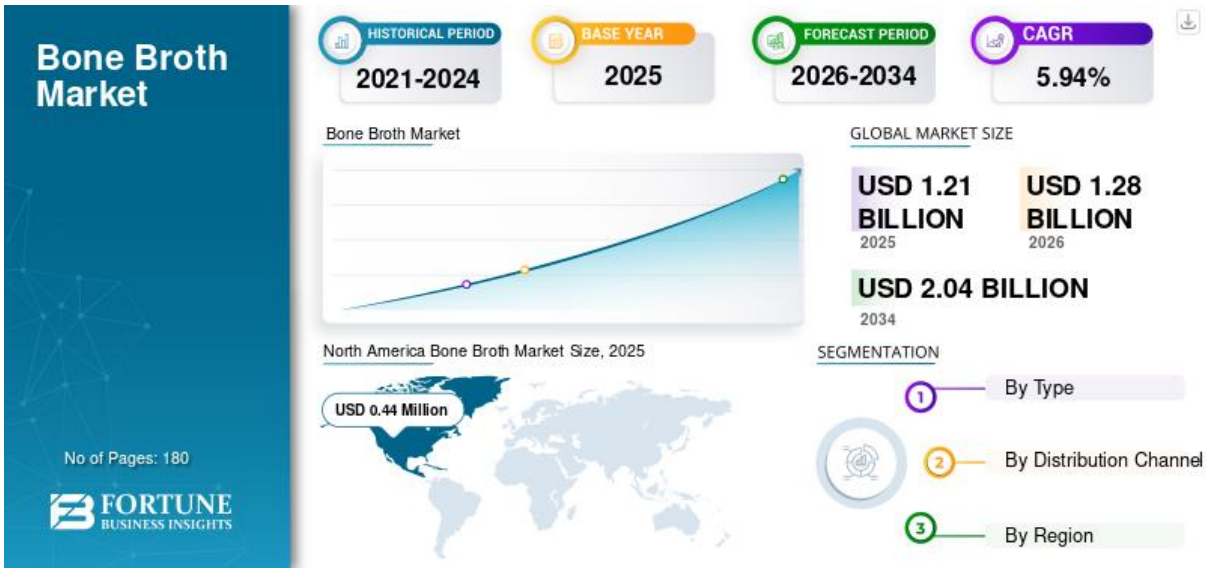


Figure 1. Global Bone Broth Market Size Growth 2025-2034 (Business Insights Research, 2026)

Focusing on the UK, the bone broth market was valued at approximately USD 675.86 million in 2024 and is expected to grow at a CAGR of around 5.01% between 2025 and 2035, reaching an estimated USD 1,156.87 million by 2035 (Spherical Insights, 2025). Spring's claim of a 50% CAGR contrasts strongly with this industry data and appears unrealistic, a discrepancy that raises credibility concerns about the pitch's broader financial projections, not just this figure in isolation. While the projected UK market size provides a reasonable basis for estimating Spring's SAM, the gap between Spring's internal projections and external data suggests the pitch may be slightly optimistic.

Historical Data for:	2020-2023
Market Size in 2024:	USD 675.86 Million
Forecast Period:	2025 - 2035

Forecast Period CAGR 2025 - 2035 :	5.01%
2035 Value Projection:	USD 1156.87 Million
Largest share in 2024	Chicken broth
Largest revenue in 2024	Canned broth

Figure 2. United Kingdom Broth Market (Spherical Insights, 2025)

In terms of distribution, most soup and similar products in the UK are sold through hypermarkets and supermarkets (61.4%), followed by convenience stores (24.7%). Spring is already present in national grocery stores, large independents, and distribution networks, which in principle aligns with this channel structure (MarketLine Industry Profile, 2024). However, retail presence alone does not constitute a competitive advantage, it is the baseline requirement to compete in this market. The more relevant question is whether Spring can secure and defend shelf space against established competitors who already benefit from existing consumer loyalty (Kemsley, 2025), and this is not addressed by the company.

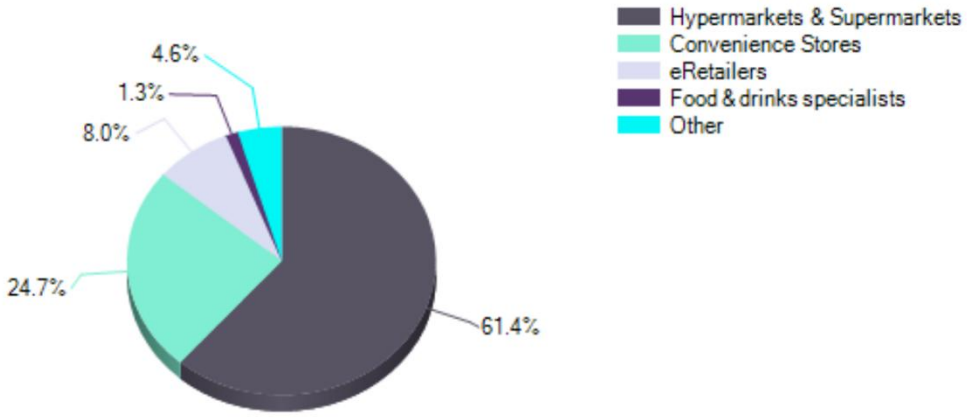


Figure 3. United Kingdom soups market distribution: % share, by value, 2023 (MarketLine Industry Profile, 2024)

However, the market is currently dominated by a small number of large players, which limits immediate growth potential. In the early stages, it is realistic to assume a modest market share of around 1%, equivalent to approximately GBP 0.6 million in revenue in 2025 (Crowdcube Capital Limited, 2026). Over time, and particularly with expansion such as the acquisition of the new factory in 2026, Spring could increase its position (The FSE Group, 2022). Assuming continued market growth and economies of scale, a 10% market share by 2034 would translate into an estimated Serviceable Obtainable Market (SOM) of approximately USD 10.97 million. However, this assumption requires scrutiny, achieving 10% share in a market dominated by established players would require sustained national distribution, consistent retail reordering, and a significant uplift in brand recognition.

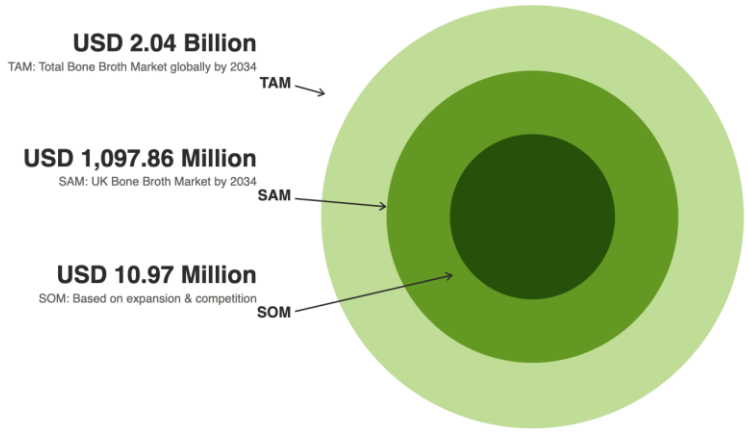


Figure 4. Showing the TAM, SAM, SOM

Competition

Spring operates in a growing and increasingly competitive market. As demand for bone broth rises, the number of players has also expanded. The main competitors are Borough Broth and Freja, which are already present in a larger number of retailers and benefit from stronger brand recognition and existing customer loyalty. In addition, both brands have gained visibility through social media, increasing their reach and engagement with consumers (Borough Broth, 2026; Freja Foods, 2026).

Spring attempts to differentiate itself through the sourcing of ingredients, highlighting the use of 100% British animals and natural production methods, alongside sustainability and flavour. However, these factors are not unique, as competitors also position themselves around similar attributes. In terms of flavour, no clear proprietary advantage or patent is disclosed, meaning that replication by competitors remains possible (PitchBook, 2026). This limits the strength of Spring's differentiation and makes it harder to establish a strong competitive advantage.

A TAKE framework analysis further supports this view, showing that Spring's main strengths lie in timing and execution, while its advantage and knowledge remain limited.

Table 1. Take framework

TIMING	Great. As bone broth is a growing tendency
ADVANTAGE	Weak. As differentiation is not clearly unique compared to competitors
KNOWLEDGE	Weak. The founder has limited experience in the food sector, and the only experienced team member left in August 2023 (LinkedIn, 2026a)
EXECUTION	High. With £0.6m in revenue last year

Table 2. Competitor strengths & weaknesses

Company	Strengths	Weakness
Freja Bone Broth	Strong online presence; broad product range; high consumer visibility	Limited innovation

Borough Broth	Premium organic positioning; featured in multiple magazines; London brand recognition	Higher price point; limited national distribution
Ossa	Fully organic; strong wellness branding; diverse protein options	Niche appeal; lower visibility outside health-focused channels
British Broth Company	UK-sourced bones; nutrient-rich; growing DTC presence	Small scale; minimal tech integration; low brand awareness
SPRING	Scalable platform; modern brand identity	New entrant; needs to build trust and visibility

The table above shows a competitive landscape highlighting differences in strengths such as brand recognition, distribution, and consumer engagement across key players. Overall, Spring's primary disadvantage is its status as a new entrant. Supermarket buyers typically require minimum volume commitments and listing fees that a £600k-revenue brand cannot credibly sustain alongside established players, making meaningful shelf space gains structurally difficult in the short term.

Key Risks and Milestones

Risk Analysis

Early-stage investments must assess risks across technology, product fit, market acceptance, distribution, and execution (Howarth, 2023).

Technical Risk:

Spring relies on small-batch food production with no proprietary technology or automation. This increases exposure to human error, higher unit costs, and food-safety incidents (CrowdCube Capital Limited, 2026).

Product Risk:

Although Spring holds national retail listings, it has not yet demonstrated strong repeat-purchase behaviour or proven long-term consumer loyalty. Shifts toward plant-based alternatives or changing dietary trends could weaken demand for bone broth, limiting product-market fit unless the range evolves with consumer expectations (CrowdCube Capital Limited, 2026).

Market Risk:

Spring operates in a crowded health-food and ready-to-eat market. Competitors offer functional beverages, wellness drinks, and plant-based alternatives that may appeal to broader audiences (Fortune Business Insights, 2026a).

Distribution Risk:

Spring depends on retail partnerships and supply-chain stability. Ingredient price volatility, logistics delays, or shortages could disrupt production and reduce availability (Anvisha Manral, 2025).

Execution Risk:

The company is led by a single director with no disclosed FMCG or food manufacturing experience, a material gap for a business planning a factory move, margin expansion, and retail scaling simultaneously. The only experienced sector team member departed in August 2023 (LinkedIn, 2026a), and the pitch omits customer acquisition cost, repeat purchase rate, and conversion metrics, making it impossible to verify whether national retail listings are generating sustainable demand. This concern is compounded by a 30% revenue decline from £851,744 in 2024 to £600,000 in 2025 despite existing retailer relationships with M&S, Ocado, and Whole Foods, a contraction the pitch does not explain. The £500,000 raise also lacks a clear capital allocation breakdown, raising questions about whether it is sufficient to complete the factory move, fund the transition period, and sustain commercial activity simultaneously (Wang and Zhou, 2003).

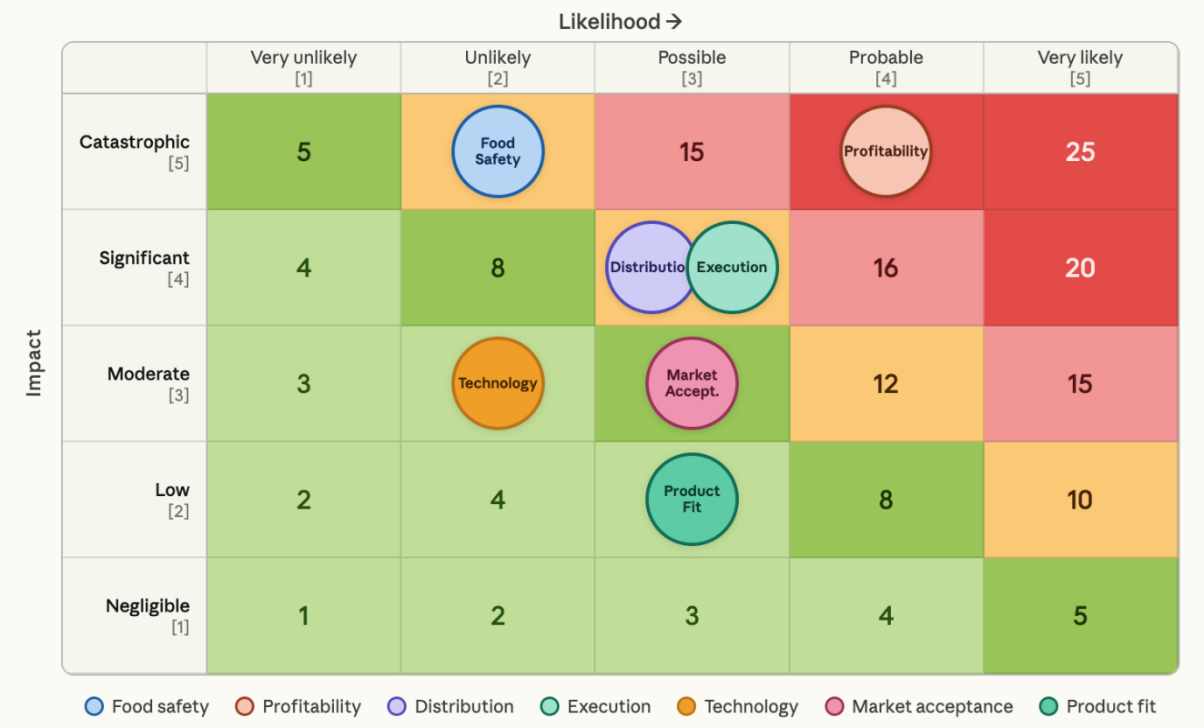


Figure 5. Risk Diagram

The highest risks relate to **Profitability**, **Distribution**, and **Execution**, as shown in the risk matrix. Without reducing cost volatility, strengthening governance, and improving operational scalability, Spring's ability to achieve sustainable growth remains limited. Overall, using a standard 5x5 framework, its combined risk profile is **High**, with meaningful uncertainty around long-term success (KPMG, 2021; Sienkiewicz, 2022).

Milestone logic and development pathways

- Completion of the move to the new production site, including installation of gas supply and upgraded equipment (Spring Pitch Deck, 2026).
- Delivery of the projected gross-margin expansion following the new factory investment.
- Continued growth with existing national retailers such as M&S, Ocado, Whole Foods and Fortnum & Mason.
- Demonstrated revenue growth aligned with projections, including the step-change enabled by increased production capacity.

Financial Viability

Key Assumptions

Spring generates £600,000 in revenue for 2025 across 30 SKUs, with a gross margin of 29% and an average selling price of £10.13 per 500ml bottle (SPRING Broth, 2025; Cantwell, 2025). The product range spans individual bottles to bulk multipacks, with an average order value of £40.52, reflecting a customer base that purchases in volume.

Product	Price
Rare spring	£10.59
Core spring	£6.25
Bone broth – 6 litre pack	£104.94
Bone broth – 4 litre pack	£71.96
Bone broth – 2 litre pack	£47.20
Mix pack – 6 litre pack	£94.02
Mix pack – 4 litre pack	£62.68
Mix pack – 2 litre pack	£40.20
Bone broth x soup – 6 litre pack	£80.10
Bone broth x soup – 4 litre pack	£53.40
Bone broth x soup – 2 litre pack	£34.20
Average Price for a bottle	£10.13

Figure 6. Price of the main products

Unit economics are acutely sensitive to input cost movements. Assuming 10 repeat orders per customer annually, baseline LTV stands at £118 under stable conditions. However, a 5% cost increase compresses margin to 27% and reduces LTV to £109, while a 10% shock, consistent with UK food inflation fluctuating between 5.7-19% over 2023-2025 (Trading Economics, 2025; Bolton, 2025), drops margin to 25% and LTV to £101, a 14% erosion from the good case.

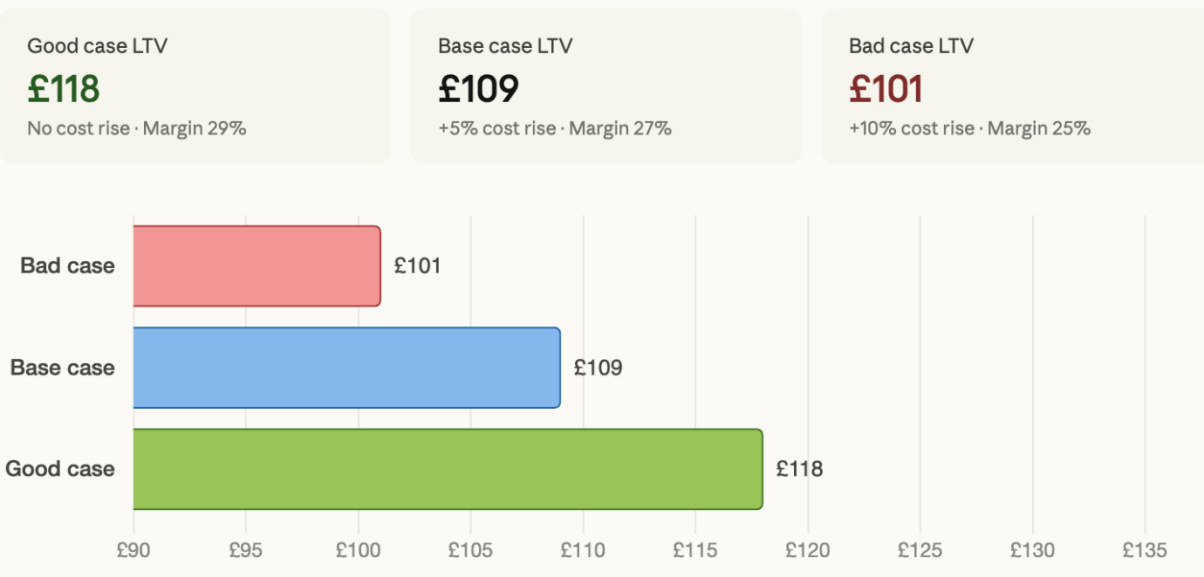


Figure 7. LTV sensitivity to cost increase scenarios| AOV £40.52 (4 bottles average)

Overall, Spring's financial viability depends on stabilising COGS and improving operational efficiency, as even modest inflationary pressures significantly erode already thin margins.

It should be noted that Spring's revenue has declined from £851,744 in 2024 to £600,000 in 2025, a 30% contraction, despite the company operating in a growing market and holding national retail listings. The pitch does not explain this decline, which is a significant credibility concern. Possible explanations include delisting by a major retailer, a deliberate SKU rationalisation, or weakening consumer demand, but none are acknowledged. For a company projecting revenue of £3.97 million by 2028, a 30% revenue decline in the base year substantially raises the burden of proof on the growth assumptions underpinning the entire return model.

Return Potential

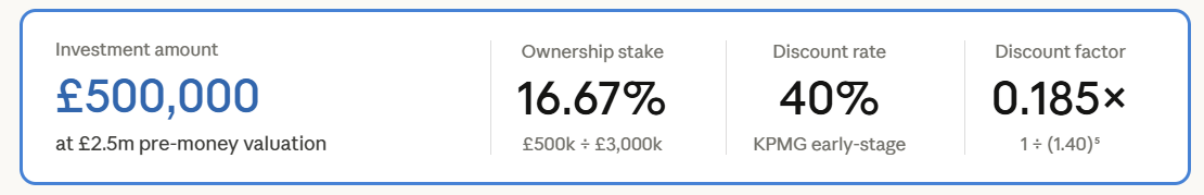
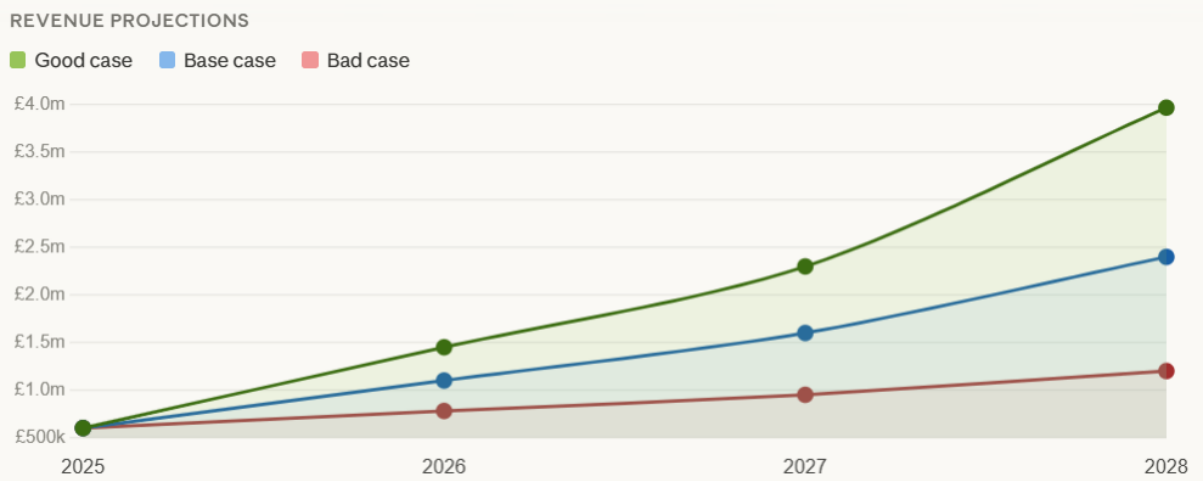


Figure 8: Assumptions on the return

Spring's projections require cautious adjustment for early-stage risks. Applying the Venture Capital Method, exit scenarios were modelled across Good, Base, and Bad cases (Faster Capital, 2025)



Year	Good case	Base case	Bad case
2025 (actual)	£600,000	£600,000	£600,000
2026	£1,450,000	£1,100,000	£780,000
2027	£2,300,000	£1,600,000	£950,000
2028 (exit)	£3,970,000	£2,400,000	£1,200,000

Figure 9. Revenue Projections

We will be assuming an exit in three years. The Good Case assumes achieving £3.9M in revenue with an 3x exit multiple, reflecting that all the conditions planned in the pitch are completed. The Base Case models £2.4M revenue and a 1.75x multiple, assuming moderate execution of the plans. The Bad Case applies a £1.2M revenue and a 0.75x multiple, reflecting weak execution (KPMG, 2021; Multiples, 2026; SPRING Broth, 2025; Auxo Capital Advisors, 2026; BizBuySell, 2021). Revenue multiples for early-stage FMCG acquisitions are significantly lower than other sector equivalents, reflecting lower scalability, higher working capital requirements, and thinner margins.



Figure 10. Scenarios 3x, 1.75x, 0.75x

Applying a 40% discount rate to account for the early-stage start-up risks, the investor returns outcomes are as seen in figure 11.

Scenario	Exit revenue	Multiple	Exit value	Undiscounted return	NPV (40% DR)	Money-on-money
Good case	£3.97m	3×	£11.91m	£1,985,997	£367,409	3.97×
Base case	£2.40m	1.75×	£4.20m	£699,900	£129,482	1.40×
Bad case	£1.20m	0.75×	£0.90m	£150,030	£27,756	0.30×

Figure 11. Exit Value by Scenario

Under FMCG-realistic multiples, the good case returns £1.99m undiscounted but just £367k in NPV terms, a modest outcome on a £500k investment. The bad case is more severe: the investor recovers only £150k nominally, representing a £350k capital loss before discounting and a near-total destruction of value after applying the 40% rate. Given Spring's declining revenue and loss-making status, it would likely price at the lower end of the 0.75-3x FMCG comparable range, making the good case less probable than the model implies.

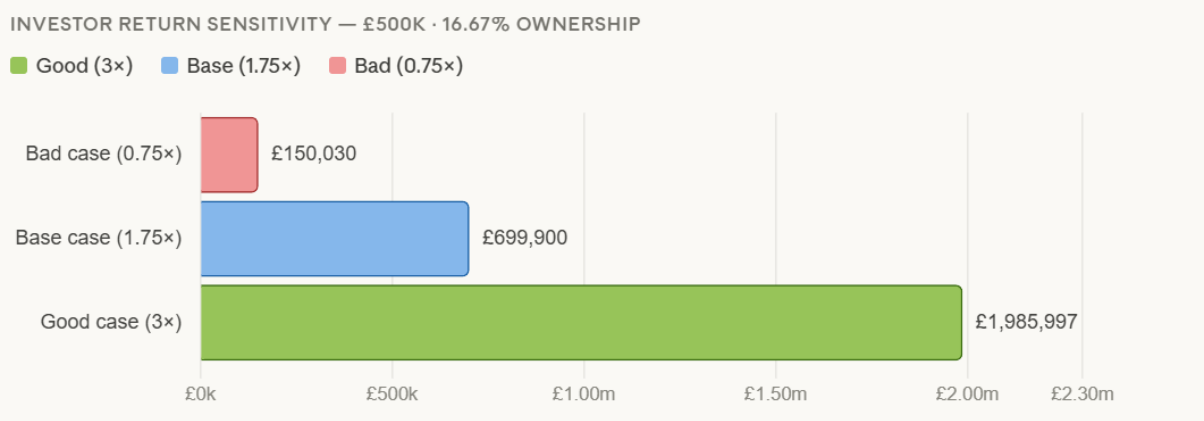


Figure 12. Investor Return by Scenario

EIS eligibility reduces the effective capital at risk from £500,000 to £350,000 via 30% income tax relief (Crowdcube Capital Limited, 2019). Even so, the bad-case undiscounted return of £150,030 still represents a £200k loss on effective capital. EIS provides partial protection, but it is not a substitute for investment quality.

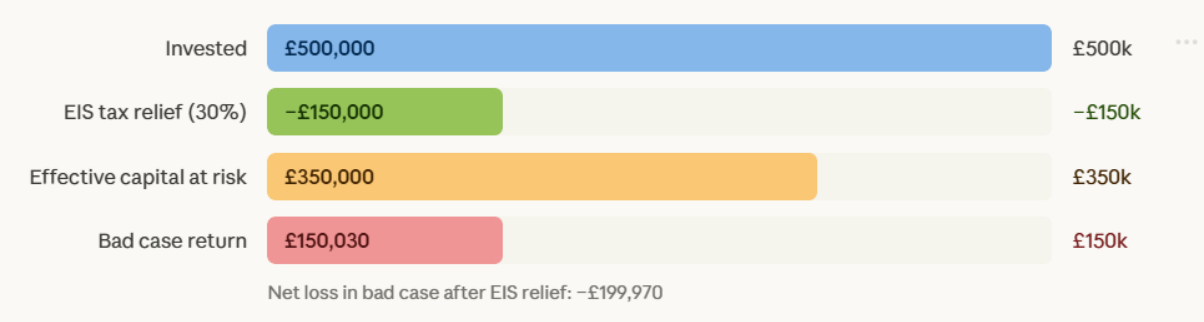


Figure 13. EIS tax relief impact on effective capital at risk and bad-case return | £500,000 investment | 30% income tax relief

Funding Proposal

Valuation

Spring's pre-money valuation of £2.5m implies a price-to-revenue multiple of approximately 4.2x on 2025 revenues, aggressive relative to FMCG acquisition comparables of 0.75-3x (KPMG, 2021; BizBuySell, 2021), and particularly difficult to justify against a backdrop of declining revenue and a 29% gross margin.

Critically, the growth required to justify this valuation depends on several execution milestones, including production expansion, margin improvement, and continued distribution growth. Without clear evidence that these can be delivered efficiently, the £2.5 million valuation is difficult to justify given Spring's current stage and performance (Rajan, 2026; Reiff, 2022).

Deal Terms

Spring's current Crowdcube offering consists of **ordinary shares** only, with no additional investor protections beyond standard pre-emption, tag-along, and drag-along rights (Crowdcube Capital Limited, 2026). This exposes investors to significant downside risk, particularly in light of Spring's declining revenue trend (from £851,744 in 2024 to £600,000 in 2025) and its sensitivity to fluctuating energy and ingredient costs. To mitigate this, stronger protections should be considered, such as structuring the investment as a **Convertible Note or SAFE,** including a valuation cap aligned with Spring's early-stage profile and a 20% discount to reflect execution risk.

The founder retains approximately 55.83% post-investment, maintaining unchallenged operational control. Ordinary shares carry no liquidation preference, meaning investors rank behind secured creditors in a downside scenario. There are no disclosed anti-dilution provisions, leaving the 16.67% stake fully exposed to down-round dilution in future capital raises. **A 1x non-participating liquidation preference** and **pro-rata rights in future rounds** would materially improve investor protection without constraining the company's ability to raise further capital.

Given Spring's reliance on future operational developments, including the new factory, margin expansion, and distribution growth, a **milestone-based funding structure** would be advisable. Capital deployment should be tied to clear and measurable targets such as increased production capacity, improved margins, and confirmed retail expansion. This approach would improve capital efficiency and ensure that funding is aligned with actual performance rather than projected outcomes.

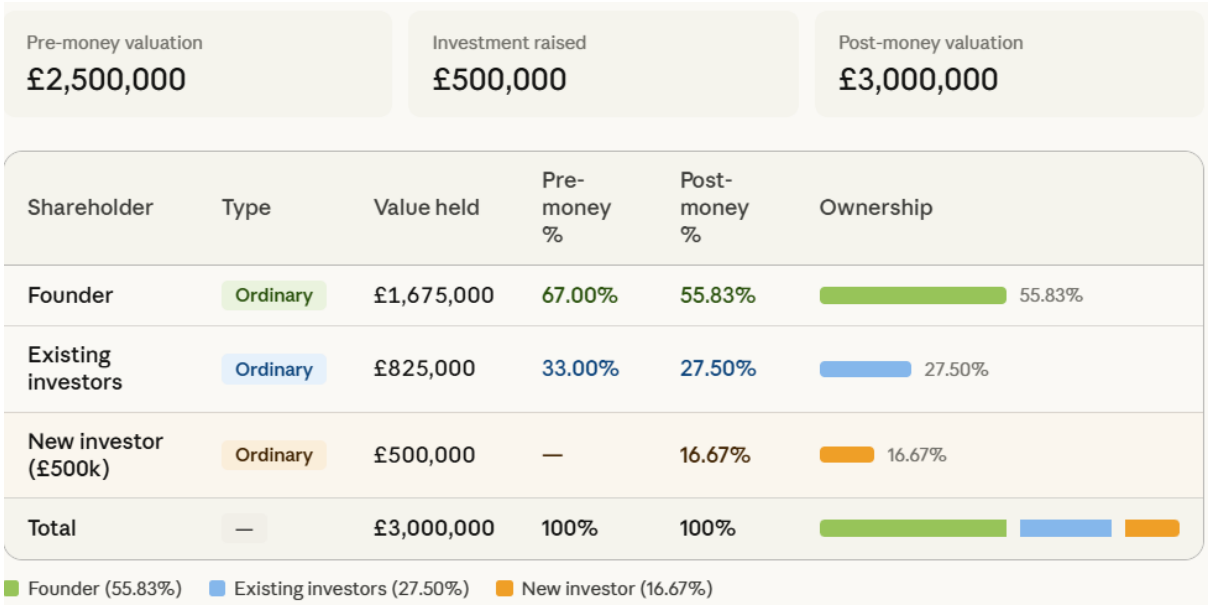


Figure 14. Cap table

Table 3. Funding Terms, Details and Reasoning

TERM	DETAILS	REASON
Convertible Note or SAFE	£3m valuation cap, 20% discount	Protects investors from overvaluation and reflects execution uncertainty
Liquidation Preference	1x non-participating	Ensures investors recover capital first in downside scenarios
Founder Vesting	4-year vesting, 1-year cliff	Aligns founder incentives and mitigates key-person risk
Board Observer Rights	Yes	Provides oversight in a company currently led by a single director
Milestone-Based Disbursements	Linked to production capacity expansion, margin improvement, and confirmed retail growth	Ensures capital efficiency and ties funding to measurable execution milestones

Conclusion

Following a critical evaluation, I recommend **not investing in Spring at this stage**. The company operates in a growing market with a coherent positioning, and its retail presence confirms a baseline level of commercial traction. However, the investment case rests on a series of unverified assumptions: that revenue will recover and grow nearly sevenfold by 2028 despite a 30% decline in the base year; that a single-director business can simultaneously execute a factory move, margin expansion, and distribution growth; and that FMCG exit multiples of 3x

will be achievable for a brand with no proprietary technology, no demonstrated repeat-purchase loyalty, and no disclosed customer economics.

In addition, the return sensitivity analysis shows that even in the good case, the NPV of £367k on a £500k investment offers modest upside relative to the risk taken, while the bad case NPV of £28k represents near-total capital destruction. The valuation of £2.5m is ambitious given £600,000 in declining revenue and a 29% gross margin, and the deal terms as structured offer insufficient downside protection. Even accounting for EIS tax relief, the risk-return profile does not justify investment. Should the opportunity be revisited at a later stage, following demonstrated revenue recovery, factory completion, and improved margin, the investment case would be substantially stronger.

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